
FREE WORKBOOK FOR US SHOPIFY BRANDS

The Black Friday Profit Plan

Plan your numbers, offer, inventory, marketing and follow-up for a stronger, more profitable Black Friday.

8

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FREE TOOLS

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How to use this workbook

Complete one part each week. Allow roughly thirty minutes. You do not need to read the workbook front to back, but you do need to calculate your numbers before you touch the offer.

Who it is for

This workbook is for US Shopify brands with an established product, regular orders and a small internal team. It is designed for teams that need to make Black Friday decisions using their own margin, inventory and acquisition costs.

What you need to hand

Every blue field is yours to fill in, either typed on screen or printed. Most figures come from Shopify, your advertising accounts or your email platform. Some pages also need information from your 3PL, carrier, customs records or tax adviser. When they do, we tell you what to ask for.

THE FOUR THINGS EVERY PAGE GIVES YOU

ON THE PAGE	WHAT IT DOES
Page outcome	Tells you what you will complete on the page
Why it matters	One line, with the Black Friday benchmark to compare against
The work	Fields, math, or a checklist. Never more than one of the three
What this changes	One line telling you what to do differently as a result

WORTH KNOWING BEFORE YOU START

- ☐ **If time is tight, prioritise Parts 01 and 08.** Part 01 tells you what you can afford. Part 08 tells you whether it was worth doing.
- ☐ **Fields with an orange underline update automatically as you enter your figures in Part 01.** Enter your costs once on page 8 and pages 9 and 10 follow. Open the PDF in Acrobat Reader for this to work, since some browser viewers ignore form calculations.
- ☐ **Every term is explained where it appears.** If a page uses a word like contribution margin or CPM, it defines it on that page, so you can start anywhere without reading what came before.
- ☐ **Everything is clickable.** Contents entries jump to the page, orange buttons open a companion spreadsheet in your browser, and the label at the bottom left of any page brings you back to contents.

Your 2026 Black Friday calendar

Find the first date that has not passed and start there. Then check the earlier rows for anything that still needs your attention. The final column shows the latest date we recommend completing each task.

DATE	WHAT IT IS	WHAT HAS TO BE DONE BY THEN
Whenever you start	The first hour	Parts 01 and the two platform checks on page 6
By mid September	Your inventory window starts closing	Offer decided, stock reordered
By end of September	Your deliverability work must begin	3PL confirmed, email authentication fixed
By mid October	Six weeks before the weekend	List warming starts, creative concepts locked
By early November	Three weeks before the weekend	Site tested, budgets ramping, campaigns live
Thu 26 November	Thanksgiving	All campaigns, codes, pages and operational checks are final. No untested changes from this point
Fri 27 November	Black Friday	Black Friday generated the highest online sales of the weekend in 2025
Sat 28 November	Small Business Saturday	Use a small-business message rather than a deeper discount
Mon 30 November	Cyber Monday	Expect higher advertising costs and set a clear spending limit
Mon 14 December	Green Monday	Shipping cutoff banners live
Fri 25 December	Christmas	Physical Christmas delivery is no longer available. Update the site, email and advertising to prioritise digital gift cards
January	Returns, repeat behaviour and lower-cost acquisition	Complete Part 08 to review returns, repeat purchases and final contribution

The holiday dates shown are fixed. Carrier deadlines and other industry marketing dates, including Green Monday and Free Shipping Day, must be confirmed before publication.

What changed since your last Black Friday

Three structural changes have altered where Black Friday revenue comes from, how customers buy and what each order costs you.

01 Black Friday starts long before Friday

Shoppers moved earlier again in 2025, and Black Friday outgrew Cyber Monday for the second year running because of it. If your plan starts on Thanksgiving, many customers will already be shopping elsewhere.

Adobe Analytics, December 2025

02 Mobile is now the primary buying experience

Mobile reached 61.6 percent of orders on Thanksgiving 2025, the first time it has passed sixty percent. Mobile checkout is not a secondary experience to check at the end. It is the primary buying experience for most customers.

Adobe Analytics, December 2025

03 Last year's cost assumptions no longer hold

The \$800 duty-free threshold is gone, carrier rates rose again, and email rules now bounce mail rather than filtering it. Customers may never see these changes, but each one affects how much contribution you keep from an order.

[Full detail on the sources page](#)

WHAT EACH ONE CHANGES ABOUT YOUR PLAN

THE SHIFT	COMMON APPROACH	WHAT TO DO INSTEAD
Starts before Friday	Plan one weekend of sends and one burst of budget	Start your plan on 1 November and treat the weekend as the busiest period
Mobile first	Check the site on a desktop and publish it	Place a test order on a mobile phone before increasing advertising spend
Cost base	Reuse last year's margin figures	Rebuild landed cost and shipping before setting the offer

2025 SHOPIFY BFCM MERCHANT SALES
\$14.6 billion, up 27 percent

Shopify, December 2025

PEAK SELLING RATE, BLACK FRIDAY 2025
\$5.1 million per minute

Shopify, December 2025

Two platform changes that can stop your promotion working

Both are US Shopify platform deadlines. Either issue can break your discount, shipping logic or checkout, even if the rest of the campaign is ready.

Shopify Scripts were discontinued on 30 June 2026

If your discount or shipping logic ran on Scripts, it is not running now. Check your checkout for any custom discount, tiered pricing or shipping rule, and move it to [Shopify Functions](#). This deadline has already passed, which is why it sits at the front of the workbook rather than buried in Part 04.

☐ Checked, not affected

☐ Affected, migration needed

Checkout extensibility deadline for non-Plus stores: 26 August 2026

If you are on Basic, Shopify or Advanced and still using checkout.liquid, support ends on that date. Any checkout customisation that still depends on checkout.liquid must be replaced with a supported app or checkout extension before the deadline. [Shopify's guide to the change](#).

☐ Migrated

☐ Not yet

NOTE THE DATE YOU CLEARED THESE

Scripts checked on

Checkout migrated on

WHAT YOU FOUND, AND WHO IS FIXING IT

WHAT THIS CHANGES

If either check needs work, name the person responsible and agree a completion date now. Test the full discount and checkout journey before the team builds campaigns around it.

01

Calculate your Black Friday margin and breakeven ROAS

Start with the numbers. Once you know what each order contributes, you can set a discount the business can afford. These four pages help you calculate your contribution margin, breakeven ROAS and maximum affordable discount. You will also review when last year's Black Friday revenue arrived.

01	Calculate your contribution margin	8
02	Calculate your breakeven ROAS	9
03	Calculate the maximum discount you can afford	10
04	Review last year's Black Friday performance	11

Calculate your contribution margin

Work out how much one Black Friday order leaves after discounts, refunds and the costs directly linked to that order.

IN PLAIN ENGLISH

Contribution per order is the amount left after subtracting every variable cost linked to that order. It is not net profit. That remaining amount helps pay for advertising, payroll, software and other overheads, and anything left becomes profit. Contribution margin is the same figure as a percentage of the selling price.

2025 SHOPIFY BFCM AVERAGE ORDER VALUE \$114.70

Shopify, December 2025

WORK IT ON ONE ORDER

	Selling price, before tax and discount	
—	Discounts and refunds, percent of revenue	
—	Landed product cost per unit	
—	Fulfilment per order, picking and packing	
—	Delivery per order, net of what the customer paid	
—	Payment and commission charges, as a percent	
=	Contribution per order	

WORKED EXAMPLE

A \$114.70 order with 4 percent lost to discounts and refunds leaves \$110.11 retained. Subtract \$34.00 product, \$4.50 fulfilment, \$8.60 delivery and \$3.30 in charges, which apply to retained revenue. Contribution per order is \$59.71, or 52.1 percent. This figure is often overstated when delivery, fulfilment, refunds or payment charges are left out.

THE MATH

Contribution margin %

$$= \text{contribution per order} \div \text{selling price} \times 100$$

Your contribution margin percentage

Price Change Calculator

Section 01 of this sheet runs the same calculation

[GET YOUR COPY](#)

WHAT THIS CHANGES

Use this number to test every discount decision in Part 02. As an EcomIQ starting point, contribution margin below roughly 35 percent usually leaves little room for a sitewide discount once Black Friday advertising costs increase.

Calculate your breakeven ROAS

Calculate the minimum ROAS your paid advertising must achieve before an order contributes anything towards overhead or profit. This number tells you whether your advertising is covering the costs of the orders it generates.

IN PLAIN ENGLISH

ROAS means return on ad spend. A ROAS of 2 means you made two dollars in sales for every dollar of ads. Breakeven ROAS is the point where an ad pays for itself and nothing more.

META CPM DURING CYBER WEEK 2 to 3x your baseline

Gupta Media 2025, Trackbee 2026

Breakeven ROAS

$= 1 \div \text{contribution margin \%}$

WORKED EXAMPLE

At the 52.1 percent contribution margin from page 8, breakeven ROAS is 1.92. Advertising that returns more than 1.92x covers the costs of those orders before overhead. Below 1.92x, the sales generated do not cover the costs of fulfilling them.

Your contribution margin percentage, from page 8

Your breakeven ROAS

Your actual ROAS last Black Friday

Difference between actual and breakeven ROAS

The ROAS shown in an advertising platform may give that platform more credit than it deserves, especially when email, SMS and other advertising are running at the same time. Compare platform ROAS with total revenue, total advertising spend and the contribution those orders produced. The most reliable test compares results with a similar audience or location that did not see the advertising, sometimes called a holdout or geographic test. This recommendation is based on EcomIQ experience rather than a published benchmark.

Profitability Dashboard

Spreadsheet, opens a copy you can edit

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WHAT THIS CHANGES

Keep this number visible during Cyber Week. It will help you decide when to increase, hold or reduce advertising spend.

Calculate the maximum discount you can afford

Calculate how far you can discount before the order stops contributing, and how many additional units you would need to sell to make up the difference.

IN PLAIN ENGLISH

Your maximum affordable discount is the deepest discount you can offer and still make money on the order. Go beyond that discount and the order loses money before advertising and overhead are included.

2025 DISCOUNT DEPTH, APPAREL **About 25 percent**

Adobe Analytics, December 2025

RUN YOUR OFFER THROUGH IT

	Full price	
—	Black Friday discount, in dollars	
=	Price the customer pays	
—	Discounts and refunds, at your rate	
—	Product, fulfilment and delivery, carried over	
—	Payment and commission charges, recalculated	
=	Contribution after discount	
=	Breakeven ROAS after the discount	

WORKED EXAMPLE

That same order at 25 percent off brings in \$86.03. Refunds take \$3.44, product, fulfilment and delivery cost \$47.10, and charges take \$2.48. Contribution falls from \$59.71 to \$33.00, and breakeven ROAS climbs from 1.92 to 2.61.

THE MATH

Units required to preserve contribution

= contribution per order now ÷ contribution per order after the discount

Additional units required to maintain contribution

WHAT THIS CHANGES

Contribution falls from \$59.71 to \$33.00 per order, so you would need roughly 1.81 times the unit volume to preserve the same total contribution. If your stock and expected visitor numbers cannot support that increase, reduce the discount.

Review last year's Black Friday performance

Revenue is easy to remember. Discounts, refunds and quieter trading days are easy to forget. Pull the actual numbers from Shopify before setting this year's targets.

IN PLAIN ENGLISH

Everything on this page comes from Shopify. Go to Analytics, then Reports, then set a custom date range covering last year's Thursday through Cyber Monday. [How Shopify reports work.](#)

WHERE TO FIND IT **Shopify Analytics, custom date range**

THE WEEKEND ITSELF, THURSDAY TO CYBER MONDAY

Gross revenue	Orders	Average order value
Conversion rate	Total discount given	Value of refunds from those orders

SALES BEFORE AND AFTER THE WEEKEND

November 1 to 26 revenue	December 1 to 24 revenue

What you would do differently, in one sentence

Total Discount Rate Tracker

Spreadsheet, opens a copy you can edit

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WHAT THIS CHANGES

Compare the weekend with the weeks before and after it. If a large share of seasonal revenue arrived outside the weekend, plan for the full trading period rather than five days.

02

Set your Black Friday offer

Now you can choose an offer that works with the margin you have available. The offer structure decides which orders receive the benefit and how much the offer costs you. By the end of these four pages, you will have a final offer, clear thresholds and agreed launch dates for the whole team.

BY MID SEPTEMBER

01	Calculate your current landed cost	13
02	Choose an offer structure your margin can support	14
03	Set thresholds using your average order value	15
04	Record and approve the final offer	16

Calculate your current landed cost

If you have not updated your landed cost since the August 2025 duty change, recalculate it before using any margin figure in this workbook. Use a recent purchase order so the result reflects current costs.

IN PLAIN ENGLISH

Landed cost is what one unit costs you by the time it is in your warehouse ready to ship. Ex works is the price before shipping, duty and handling. De minimis was the rule that allowed qualifying parcels valued below \$800 to enter the US without duty.

CUSTOMS ENTRY COST PER PARCEL, NOW **About \$15 to \$25**

GingerControl, 2026

The \$800 duty-free threshold is gone

Section 321 de minimis was repealed in full on 29 August 2025. Every inbound parcel now needs an HTS code, pays applicable duty, and carries a formal or informal customs entry. For brands importing smaller parcels, the fixed customs entry charge can affect the per-unit cost more than the duty rate itself.

WORKED EXAMPLE

You ordered 1,000 units at \$8.00 each. After allowing for damaged units, 950 are available to sell. Freight was \$1,800, duty 12 percent, customs and broker fees \$250, inspection \$300 and warehouse handling \$150. The total cost is \$11,460. Divide that by the 950 units you can sell and the landed cost is \$12.06 per unit, which is 50.8 percent more than the supplier invoice.

Units purchased	Units you can actually sell	Supplier price per unit
Freight for the whole order	Duty rate	Customs and broker fees
Inspection and quality checks	Warehouse handling	Landed cost per unit, now

Landed Product Cost Calculator

Spreadsheet, opens a copy you can edit

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WHAT THIS CHANGES

Enter the updated landed cost in the margin calculation on page 8, then recalculate contribution before approving the offer.

Choose an offer structure your margin can support

A sitewide discount applies to every eligible order, including customers who would have bought anyway, which makes it the most expensive option for your contribution margin. Choose the structure first, then set the percentage, threshold or gift value.

IN PLAIN ENGLISH

Sitewide means the discount applies to everything. A tiered threshold means the discount grows as someone spends more. Gift with purchase means a free item instead of money off.

TOTAL DISCOUNT RATE, A HEALTHY STARTING POINT Under 15 percent of gross sales

EcomIQ guidance, not a measured benchmark

STRUCTURE	EFFECT ON MARGIN	EFFECT ON ORDER VALUE	APPROPRIATE WHEN
Sitewide percentage off	Lower on every order	No change	Margin above 55 percent and you need volume
Tiered spend thresholds	Protected below the threshold	Increases order value	You have range and a low order value
Bundles	Protected if priced correctly	Increases order value	Products that genuinely go together
Gift with purchase	Fixed cost per order	Small increase	You have stock to clear, or want customers to try a product
Free shipping threshold	Depends on delivery cost	Increases order value	Shipping cost causes abandonment
Early access for your list	No extra discount	No change	Your list is engaged and you would rather not discount

These ratings are based on practical ecommerce experience rather than a controlled study. The cited analysis found that some customers acquired through discounts spent less over the following twelve months. Source: Niblin, 2026.

The structure you are choosing	Percentage, threshold or gift value	Why you chose it

Welcome Discount Worksheet

Spreadsheet, opens a copy you can edit

GET YOUR COPY

WHAT THIS CHANGES

Model the chosen offer against the breakeven ROAS on page 9. If your advertising is unlikely to stay above the new breakeven ROAS, change the offer rather than accepting an unprofitable target.

Set thresholds using your average order value

A round number may look neat, but it may not encourage customers to add another item. Set the threshold using what customers already spend and the cost of the reward.

IN PLAIN ENGLISH

A threshold is the amount a customer has to spend to get something, usually free shipping or a bigger discount. Average order value is your total sales divided by your number of orders.

2025 SHOPIFY BFCM AVERAGE ORDER VALUE **\$114.70**

[Shopify, December 2025](#)

EcomIQ starting range

= set a threshold 15 to 25 percent above average order value, then test it

WORKED EXAMPLE

Assume an average order value of \$80, which puts your range at \$92 to \$100. Set it at \$95. A customer at \$80 adds a \$15 item to reach it, so the order becomes \$95. You cover roughly \$9 of delivery cost, while the customer adds another \$15 to the order. At \$100 the customer must add \$20 rather than \$15, which may reduce the share who reach it, so test the result against your own baskets. After the test, compare average order value, conversion rate and contribution per session with the period before the threshold changed. If average order value does not change, check how many orders already exceeded the threshold before increasing it.

Your average order value, last 90 days

Your Black Friday average order value, last year

Free shipping threshold

What shipping costs you at that value

Tier one threshold and reward

Tier two threshold and reward

Give the test enough time and enough orders before deciding whether the threshold works. Compare average order value, conversion rate and contribution per session rather than total revenue.

Free Shipping Threshold Test

Spreadsheet, opens a copy you can edit

GET YOUR COPY

WHAT THIS CHANGES

Check contribution after the reward is applied. If every qualifying order falls below the contribution margin you calculated on page 8, the threshold is costing more than the additional order value creates.

Record and approve the final offer

Record the final offer, margin and dates in one place, then share it with everyone building campaigns, pages, discount codes or forecasts.

IN PLAIN ENGLISH

Locking the offer means writing it down and agreeing not to change it. Every email, ad and page you build from here assumes this page is final.

LOCK IT BY **End of September**

EcomIQ guidance, not a measured benchmark

THE OFFER

Offer as the customer will see it

Public launch date and time

Closing date and time

Early access opens

Contribution margin after discount

Breakeven ROAS

Revenue target

WHAT WE ARE NOT DOING

Write down the alternative you considered and why you decided against it. This gives the team a clear answer if the idea is raised again during Cyber Week

SENSE CHECK BEFORE YOU MOVE ON

- ☐ Approved by the person accountable for margin and revenue
- ☐ Shared with everyone responsible for pricing, campaigns or site updates
- ☐ Discount codes built and tested, not just planned

WHAT THIS CHANGES

Make any changes before production begins. Once the team starts building from this page, every later change means updating email, advertising, site copy and discount settings again.

03

Inventory and fulfilment

Check that you have enough stock, fulfilment capacity and available cash to support the number of orders you expect. Lead times are longer than they were, shipping costs more than last year, and your 3PL receiving cutoff, not your campaign calendar, sets the last date new stock can arrive and still be ready to sell.

BY THE END OF SEPTEMBER

01	Forecast demand for your top-selling SKUs	18
02	Calculate your last safe reorder date	19
03	Confirm your 3PL deadlines, capacity and Cyber Week surcharges	20
04	Calculate your current delivery cost per order	21
05	Check for new sales-tax obligations after Black Friday	22

Forecast demand for your top-selling SKUs

Start with the products you expect to sell the most, then compare the forecast with the stock you can actually sell. In Shopify, go to Analytics, then Reports, then Sales by product, and select last year’s Black Friday weekend.

IN PLAIN ENGLISH

A SKU is one specific product variant, for example one size in one colour, and it is the level your stock is counted at. Your top-selling SKUs are the few that make most of your sales.

PEAK SELLING RATE, BLACK FRIDAY 2025 **\$5.1 million per minute across Shopify**

Shopify, December 2025

PRODUCT	SOLD LAST BLACK FRIDAY	FORECAST	SELLABLE STOCK	RISK
				Low
				Medium
				High

Start with last year’s unit sales, then adjust for growth, availability, price and the products you plan to promote this year. Your revenue target is not an inventory forecast. If a SKU sold out last year, more customers may have wanted it than your sales figures show. Treat last year’s sales as the minimum forecast before applying this year’s assumptions. There is no published benchmark for how much of Black Friday revenue comes from a small number of products, so use your own sales history.

SUPPLIERS CONTACTED, AND WHAT THEY SAID

WHAT THIS CHANGES

Decide what to do with each high-risk product this week: reorder it, reduce its advertising, limit how many units each customer can buy, or remove it from paid promotion.

Calculate your last safe reorder date

Work backwards from your 3PL receiving cutoff rather than from Black Friday, and include every stage between placing the order and having stock ready to sell.

IN PLAIN ENGLISH

Lead time is how long it takes from placing an order with your supplier to having stock you can sell. Customs clearance is the wait while your shipment is processed on arrival in the US.

DE MINIMIS REPEALED IN FULL 29 August 2025

US Customs and Border Protection

COUNT BACK FROM YOUR 3PL RECEIVING CUTOFF DATE

	3PL receiving cutoff	
—	Days to receive and put away	
—	Domestic freight days	
—	Customs clearance days	
—	International freight days	
—	Production lead time	
=	Latest purchase-order date	

WORKED EXAMPLE

3PL receiving cutoff 6 November. Subtract 3 days for receiving and put-away, 4 days for domestic freight, 7 days for customs clearance, 25 days for sea freight and 30 days for production. That is 69 days in total, making 29 August your last safe order date. If any stage is measured in business days rather than calendar days, the safe date moves earlier still.

Cash Cycle Calculator

Free tool on our site, works in your browser

OPEN TOOL

WHAT THIS CHANGES

If the last safe order date has passed, plan the campaign around the stock you already have. Adjust the offer, forecast and advertising plan to match.

Confirm your 3PL deadlines, capacity and Cyber Week surcharges

Send these questions before the end of September. Ask your 3PL to confirm the dates, capacity and charges in writing so the whole team is working from the same information.

IN PLAIN ENGLISH

A 3PL is a third-party logistics company, the warehouse that holds your stock and ships your orders. If you pack orders yourself, answer these questions about your own setup.

- ☐ **Inbound receiving cutoff.** The last date they can receive and put away new stock before Black Friday.
- ☐ **Same-day shipping cutoff.** The latest time an order can reach the 3PL and still ship that day, and whether that time changes during Cyber Week.
- ☐ **Cyber Week surcharges.** Which additional charges apply, at what rate, and from which date.
- ☐ **Guaranteed daily capacity and overflow process.** The number of orders per day they will commit to processing, and what happens above that volume: delayed fulfilment, an added fee, a secondary facility, or they cannot guarantee when the additional orders will ship.
- ☐ **Carriers used.** Which carriers they will use over the weekend, and what happens if one reaches capacity.
- ☐ **Weekend cover.** Whether they process orders on the Saturday and Sunday of the Black Friday weekend.

Sent on

Answered in writing on

Fulfilment Questions

Printable sheet, downloads to your device

[DOWNLOAD](#)

WHAT YOUR 3PL CONFIRMED, AND WHEN

WHAT THIS CHANGES

Replace every estimated fulfilment date in your plan with the dates your 3PL has confirmed in writing.

Calculate your current delivery cost per order

Carrier rates increased again and the surcharge thresholds changed. If you are still using last year’s delivery cost, update it from current invoices before approving the offer.

IN PLAIN ENGLISH

A general rate increase is the annual price rise carriers apply to everything. A surcharge is an extra fee on top, for things like a large box or a home delivery address.

2026 CARRIER INCREASES **5.9 percent headline, 8 to 12 percent effective on some shipments**

UPS and FedEx published rates; LateShipment, 2026

WHAT CHANGED	DETAIL	EFFECTIVE
UPS general rate increase	5.9 percent average	22 December 2025
FedEx general rate increase	5.9 percent average	5 January 2026
FedEx Ground base rates	About 8.4 percent	5 January 2026
Residential surcharge	Up about 8 percent	Both carriers
Additional handling and large package, by cube	Above 10,368 and 17,280 cubic inches	Both carriers

Remeasure the three cartons carrying most of your volume. Package dimensions are rounded up, which can move a package into a more expensive pricing band even when the product has not changed. Source: UPS and FedEx, 2026.

WORKED EXAMPLE

You paid \$9,400 to deliver 1,000 orders and collected \$4,800 in shipping charges. Net delivery cost was \$4,600, or \$4.60 per order. If carrier costs rise to between \$10.15 and \$10.53 per order while customer charges stay the same, net delivery cost rises to between \$5.35 and \$5.73 per order. That is the figure page 8 needs.

What you paid to deliver, last full month

What customers paid you

Orders you sent

Net delivery cost per order

Delivery Cost Sheet

Spreadsheet, opens a copy you can edit

GET YOUR COPY

WHAT THIS CHANGES

Enter the net figure, what you pay less what customers pay, in the delivery line on page 8. Then multiply the difference per order by your forecast order volume to see the total impact.

Check for new sales-tax obligations after Black Friday

A strong Black Friday can push a growing brand past a state sales-tax threshold within days, including in states you have not sold much into before.

IN PLAIN ENGLISH

Economic nexus means a state can require you to collect its sales tax once you sell enough into that state, even if you have no office, staff or stock there.

MOST COMMON STATE THRESHOLD **\$100,000 in in-state sales**

Avalara and Sales Tax Institute, August 2026

- ☐ **Pull your sales by state for the last twelve months.** In Shopify, go to Analytics, then Reports, then Sales by billing region.
- ☐ **Flag any state within twenty percent of a threshold.** Estimate Black Friday sales in those states to see which thresholds you may cross.
- ☐ **Check the transaction-count test where it still applies.** Brands with lower average order values may reach a transaction-count threshold before reaching a sales-value threshold. Confirm the current rule in every state approaching a threshold rather than relying on a remembered count.
- ☐ **Confirm where you are already registered.** Registering in a state and collecting tax there are separate steps. Check both.
- ☐ **Assign an owner now for threshold monitoring, registration and collection.** Do not leave the decision until the annual tax return is being prepared.

States closest to a threshold	Named owner and next action

Most states use \$100,000 in in-state sales. California, New York and Texas sit at \$500,000, Alabama and Mississippi at \$250,000. States have been dropping the transaction test steadily, so check current thresholds rather than working from a figure you remember. Source: Avalara and Sales Tax Institute, August 2026.

WHAT THIS CHANGES

This may not change the campaign, but crossing a threshold can create registration, collection and reporting obligations straight after Black Friday.

04

Check site speed and mobile checkout

Before advertising costs rise, check that mobile visitors can load the site, understand the offer and complete checkout without unnecessary delays. These two checks help you avoid paying more to send customers to a site that loses them.

BY EARLY NOVEMBER

01	Test your site speed before Black Friday	24
02	Test your checkout on a mobile phone	25

Test your site speed before Black Friday

When advertising costs rise, every visitor who leaves because a page is slow becomes more expensive to replace.

IN PLAIN ENGLISH

Core Web Vitals are three speed measurements Google publishes. LCP is how long the main content takes to appear. INP is how fast the page responds when someone taps. CLS is how much the page jumps while loading.

0.1 SECOND FASTER ON MOBILE 8.4 percent more retail conversions

Google and Deloitte, Milliseconds Make Millions

- ☐ **Test your homepage and one product page.** Go to pagespeed.web.dev, paste the URL and read the mobile results rather than desktop.
- ☐ **Check INP as well as load time.** Google classifies an INP of 200 milliseconds or less as good. Record the result rather than assuming the theme passes.
- ☐ **Review every installed app.** In Shopify, go to Settings, then Apps and sales channels. For each app, note who uses it and what it does. Remove or disable anything that slows the site without supporting sales or operations.
- ☐ **Compress your hero and collection images.** Large uncompressed images are a common cause of slow ecommerce pages.
- ☐ **Test on a mid-range Android using mobile data.** Not on your own phone using office wifi.

Largest contentful paint

Interaction to next paint

Cumulative layout shift

Around 39 percent of ecommerce sites pass all three Core Web Vitals. If your site does not pass all three checks, you are not alone. Use the results to decide which issue to fix first. Sources: HTTPArchive 2025, Web Almanac 2025.

WHAT THIS CHANGES

Save your current scores before adding any Black Friday popups, countdowns or other site changes. Retest after every material change.

Test your checkout on a mobile phone

Place a real order on your phone before you increase advertising spend. Use a card rather than a saved wallet so you see every step a new customer has to complete.

IN PLAIN ENGLISH

Express payments are the buttons that let someone pay without typing card details, like Shop Pay, Apple Pay and Google Pay.

SHOP PAY SHARE OF BFCM 2025 ORDERS 32 percent

[Shopify, December 2025](#)

- ☐ **Buy something from yourself on your phone, start to finish.** Time how long it takes from product page to confirmation.
- ☐ **Check express payment options appear without scrolling.** Shop Pay, Apple Pay and Google Pay.
- ☐ **Check the full discount code experience.** Confirm the code field is easy to find, the code applies correctly, any exclusions are explained and the final total matches the advertised offer.
- ☐ **Check the shipping cost appears before the final step.** Unexpected costs at the end are a common reason customers abandon checkout.
- ☐ **Check the free shipping threshold message appears in the cart.** Customers need to know how much more to add.
- ☐ **Test with one item and with four.** Multi item carts break more often than single item ones.

Seconds to complete checkout

Tested on which device

Mobile Checkout Checklist

Printable sheet, downloads to your device

[DOWNLOAD](#)

WHAT THIS CHANGES

Write down anything that is unclear, unexpected or takes longer than it should. Fix any confusing price, discount, shipping charge, field or instruction before increasing advertising spend.

05

Email and SMS

Email and SMS let you speak directly to people who already know your brand, without paying for every impression. The sends happen in November, but the preparation needs to start in October. Use October to check deliverability, compliance and the automated messages customers will receive.

START MID OCTOBER

01	Check email authentication and deliverability	27
02	Plan your six-week email sending ramp	28
03	Check your SMS compliance before November	29
04	Audit your automated email flows	30
05	Plan your Black Friday email and SMS sends	31

Check email authentication and deliverability

Email authentication is required for reliable delivery to major inbox providers. If the required settings are missing, some messages may be rejected instead of reaching the inbox or spam folder.

IN PLAIN ENGLISH

SPF, DKIM and DMARC are three settings that prove to Gmail and Outlook that your email really came from you. Your email platform shows whether each one is passing.

SPAM COMPLAINT RATE CEILING Under 0.3 percent

Google and Yahoo bulk sender requirements

- ☐ **SPF, DKIM and DMARC all passing.** In Klaviyo, go to Settings, then Domains and hosting. Confirm each status and resolve any warning before you increase sending volume.
- ☐ **One-click unsubscribe available in the message header.** Required, and separate from the link in your footer.
- ☐ **Keep the spam-complaint rate below 0.3 percent.** Sign in at postmaster.google.com with your sending domain to see it, and aim materially lower during normal sending.
- ☐ **Check Microsoft delivery separately.** Outlook and Hotmail began rejecting messages at the server in May 2025 and assess sender reputation differently.
- ☐ **Send from a subdomain you control.** Not a shared sending domain provided by the platform.

Complaint rate, last 30 days

Date you checked

Gmail moved to permanent rejections in November 2025, and Microsoft began rejecting at the server in May 2025. Even if your emails delivered well last year, check the settings again. The requirements and enforcement have changed. Sources: Google and Yahoo bulk sender requirements, Microsoft sender requirements.

ANYTHING FAILING, AND WHO IS FIXING IT

WHAT THIS CHANGES

The technical settings may be quick to fix, but rebuilding sender reputation takes longer. Complete the technical work early enough for reputation to settle before your biggest sends.

Plan your six-week email sending ramp

Black Friday is the week you send the most email all year. Increasing volume and audience size too quickly can affect delivery when it matters most.

IN PLAIN ENGLISH

Warming means building up how much email you send gradually. A sudden jump in volume looks like spam to Gmail and Outlook, even when the mail is legitimate.

START WARMING At least six weeks before the weekend

EcomIQ guidance, not a measured benchmark

WHERE YOU ARE STARTING FROM

Sends per week now

Sends per week during Cyber Week

Peak weekly sends divided by current weekly sends

YOUR RAMP, WEEK BY WEEK

Week of 12 October

Week of 19 October

Week of 26 October

Week of 2 November

Week of 9 November

Week of 16 November

SENSE CHECK BEFORE YOU MOVE ON

☐ Send to your most engaged contacts first, then widen the audience

☐ Exclude contacts who have not opened or clicked for a long period

☐ Check your complaint rate weekly during the ramp

WHAT THIS CHANGES

If peak weekly volume is more than roughly four times your current volume, agree the weekly sending schedule and recipient groups before adding more campaigns.

Check your SMS compliance before November

Check consent, 10DLC registration, quiet hours and opt-out handling before your Black Friday sends begin. This page also corrects one piece of outdated advice.

IN PLAIN ENGLISH

TCPA is the US law covering marketing text messages. 10DLC is the registration that lets a business send texts from an ordinary phone number rather than a short code.

TCPA STATUTORY DAMAGES **\$500 to \$1,500 per message**

[Telephone Consumer Protection Act](#)

You do not need separate one-to-one consent

The FCC one-to-one consent rule was vacated in January 2025, a day before it was due to take effect, and formally repealed in September 2025. The standard is prior express written consent, as it was before. Plenty of guides written in late 2024 still say otherwise.

- ☐ **10DLC registration current.** Missing or incomplete registration can reduce message throughput and delivery. [What 10DLC registration involves.](#)
- ☐ **Consent language on every collection point.** Including the popup you added for Black Friday.
- ☐ **Quiet hours respected across time zones.** Schedule messages using the recipient local time, including Alaska and Hawaii where applicable.
- ☐ **Opt-out handling is automatic and has been tested.** Send a test “STOP” message and verify that the profile is immediately suppressed across every connected workflow.

COMPLIANCE GAPS FOUND, AND THE FIX

WHAT THIS CHANGES

SMS can reach customers who are ready to buy, but the consent and sending rules need to be followed carefully. Complete and document the checks in October so everyone sending SMS in November knows which rules to follow.

Audit your automated email flows

Automated emails arrive when a customer takes an action, such as viewing a product or leaving checkout. If one of those emails contains the wrong offer or code, more customers will see the mistake during Black Friday.

IN PLAIN ENGLISH

A flow is an automated email that sends when someone does something, like abandoning a cart. A campaign is a one-off email you send to a list on a chosen date.

FLOW SHARE OF EMAIL REVENUE **About 41 percent**

Klaviyo benchmarks, 2026

FLOW	ACTIVE	REVIEWED FOR BLACK FRIDAY	ATTRIBUTED REVENUE, LAST 90 DAYS
Welcome			
Browse abandonment			
Cart abandonment			
Checkout abandonment			
Back in stock			
Post purchase			
Winback			

Flows earn roughly eighteen times more per person than one-off campaigns. For each flow, check the offer, discount code, timing, exclusions, stock message, delivery promise and who receives it. A welcome flow promising ten percent off during a weekend where everything is twenty-five percent off contradicts the current Black Friday offer and may confuse the customer. Source: Klaviyo benchmarks, 2026.

The flow you are fixing first

By when

Email Marketing Audit

Free tool on our site, works in your browser

OPEN TOOL

WHAT THIS CHANGES

Start with the flow that generated the most attributed revenue in the last 90 days. These automated emails keep sending during Black Friday, so review them before traffic increases.

Plan your Black Friday email and SMS sends

Before November, decide who each message is for, whether it goes by email or SMS, what it needs to say and who is responsible for sending it.

IN PLAIN ENGLISH

A segment is a saved group of contacts, for example everyone who bought in the last ninety days. Early access means letting your list buy before the public sale opens.

2026 CYBER WEEK Thu 26 to Mon 30 November

US federal holiday calendar

DATE	SEGMENT	EMAIL / SMS	MAIN MESSAGE	RESPONSIBLE PERSON	STATUS
Mon 16 Nov			Early access opens for your list		
Thu 19 Nov			Useful content before the offer		
Mon 23 Nov			Full offer details		
Wed 25 Nov			Reminder before the public sale		
Thu 26 Nov			Thanksgiving		
Fri 27 Nov			Public offer launches		
Sat 28 Nov			Small Business Saturday		
Sun 29 Nov			Offer reminder or customer review		
Mon 30 Nov			Cyber Monday		
Tue 1 Dec			Final reminder with closing time		

WHAT THIS CHANGES

Add the copy and the person responsible when you set each date, so nothing is left unfinished in November.

06

Black Friday advertising

You will pay two to three times your usual cost to reach the same person during Cyber Week. These four pages help you prepare your ads, campaigns, tracking and spending limits before Cyber Week advertising costs rise.

OCTOBER INTO NOVEMBER

01	Finalise your Black Friday ads	33
02	Set your advertising budget and spending limits	34
03	Launch paid campaigns before Cyber Week	35
04	Check your Google product feed and promotion settings	36

Finalise your Black Friday ads

Prepare several genuinely different ad ideas, then create the sizes and formats each one needs. Decide how many ideas you will test, how many versions each needs and when production stops.

IN PLAIN ENGLISH

An ad includes the image or video, the words shown in it and the accompanying copy. A concept is the main idea behind the ad. Variants are different versions of that idea.

SET YOUR LOCK DATE At least two weeks before the weekend

EcomIQ guidance, not a measured benchmark

WHAT YOU ARE MAKING

Concepts	Variants per concept	Total assets
Who is making them	First review	Lock date

WHAT EACH CONCEPT LEADS WITH

Concept one	Concept two	Concept three

SENSE CHECK BEFORE YOU MOVE ON

☐ Every video communicates the core message with sound off	☐ The offer can be read immediately	☐ Native versions produced for feed, Stories and Reels, not one asset resized
---	--	--

WHAT THIS CHANGES

Once the ads are approved, avoid last-minute replacements unless the offer is wrong, an ad is barely being shown or performance is consistently poor. During Cyber Week, adjust spending and targeting rather than producing new ads at short notice.

Set your advertising budget and spending limits

Cyber Monday is routinely the most expensive advertising day of the year. Decide in advance how quickly spending can increase, which ROAS must be maintained and the maximum you will spend each day.

IN PLAIN ENGLISH

CPM means cost per thousand views. It is what you pay to show your ad a thousand times, and it rises when more advertisers are competing for the same people.

META CPM, Q4 2025 US AVERAGE **About \$25, against \$16 in January**

Sovran Benchmarks via Clouted, 2026

WORKED EXAMPLE

Baseline \$400 a day at a \$12 CPM. Increase 25 percent weekly from 9 November and you reach roughly \$780 a day. If Cyber Week CPMs run 2.5 times baseline, that \$780 buys what \$312 used to. At a breakeven ROAS of 1.9, \$780 of spend needs \$1,482 in attributed sales.

YOUR BASELINE

Daily spend now	Your usual CPM	Your breakeven ROAS
Minimum blended ROAS before you reduce spend	Maximum daily advertising spend	

THE RAMP

Week of 9 November	Week of 16 November	Week of 23 November
Black Friday, 27 November	Cyber Monday, 30 November	Total planned spend

CPMs fell to a thirteen-month low by January 2026, roughly thirty-eight percent below November. Before putting every remaining dollar into Cyber Monday, compare that expected return with what the same budget could buy in January. Source: Sovran via Clouted, 2026.

True CAC Calculator

Free tool on our site, works in your browser

OPEN TOOL

WHAT THIS CHANGES

If higher advertising costs push expected ROAS below breakeven, reduce the budget, improve contribution per order or change the offer. Do not rely on Cyber Week demand to fix an unprofitable plan.

Launch paid campaigns before Cyber Week

A campaign launched on Black Friday uses the most expensive advertising of the year to discover its audience, placements and conversion pattern. Launch early enough for the advertising platform to gather useful conversion data before Cyber Week costs rise.

IN PLAIN ENGLISH

Prospecting means advertising to people who do not know you. Retargeting means advertising to people who already visited. The learning phase is the first few days while the platform works out who to show your ad to.

LAUNCH AHEAD OF THE WEEKEND Three to five days, at minimum

Practitioner consensus, Metalla Digital 2025

CAMPAIGN	OBJECTIVE	LAUNCH DATE	BUDGET AT LAUNCH
New customers, pre-offer			
New customers, offer live			
Retargeting, site visitors			
Retargeting, cart and checkout			
Existing customers			

Audiences built and populated by

Pixel and Conversions API verified on

Paid Media Audit

Free tool on our site, works in your browser

OPEN TOOL

WHAT THIS CHANGES

By Monday of Cyber Week, every planned campaign should be running, checked and recording spend, sales and conversions correctly. If you need to launch something later, write down why it is needed, what it can spend and when it should be stopped.

Check your Google product feed and promotion settings

Your product feed tells Google which products are available, what they cost and whether they can appear in ads and shopping results.

IN PLAIN ENGLISH

Your product feed is the file that sends your products to Google. Merchant Center is where Google stores and checks it. A disapproval means a product has been rejected and will not show.

MERCHANT CENTER MINIMUM IMAGE SIZE **Moving to 500 by 500 pixels**

Google product data specification, 2026

- ☐ **Product feed shows current prices and stock.** [Open Google Merchant Center to review product issues](#), then check the last update time under Products.
- ☐ **No unresolved product disapprovals.** Merchant Center flags these under Products, then Needs attention. Product reviews and appeals can take several days, so resolve them before Cyber Week.
- ☐ **Product images meet the new minimum resolution.** Warnings began in April 2026.
- ☐ **Sale price and promotion data set up correctly.** Confirm price, sale price and promotion data match the landing page, so the price and offer shown in Google match your product page.
- ☐ **Out-of-stock products removed or marked unavailable automatically.** Set this to update automatically so sold-out products do not need to be removed by hand during Cyber Week.
- ☐ **Shipping, handling-time and order-cutoff attributes are current.** These settings affect the delivery information Google may show with the product.

Feed checked on

Disapprovals outstanding

WHAT THIS CHANGES

Complete the first feed audit in October and repeat it after the final price, inventory and shipping settings go live. Reviews, appeals and product updates can take several days, so complete the checks before the final week of November.

07

Your Black Friday operating plan

Keep these four pages open during Cyber Week. Add the person responsible for each task and update the figures each day.

THE WEEK OF 23 NOVEMBER

01	Check the customer experience for gift buyers	38
02	Publish your Christmas shipping deadlines	39
03	Plan customer-support coverage for Cyber Week	40
04	Track your Black Friday performance daily	41

Check the customer experience for gift buyers

Two-thirds of reported spending over the 2025 weekend went on gifts. Someone buying a gift has different questions from someone buying for themselves. They need to know who the product suits, how it arrives, when it will be delivered and how returns work.

IN PLAIN ENGLISH

A gift guide is a collection page built for someone buying for another person, usually grouped by price or by who it suits, rather than by product type.

SHARE OF WEEKEND SPEND ON GIFTS, 2025 **About 67 percent of per-person spending**

NRF and Prosper Insights, December 2025

- ☐ **A gift guide or gifting collection.** Let customers browse by recipient, price, use case and expected delivery date.
- ☐ **Let customers add a gift note at checkout.** A simple text field is enough.
- ☐ **Gift cards visible and easy to find.** They remain available after physical delivery deadlines have passed.
- ☐ **Gift-friendly price points.** Include options at lower price points if your range allows.
- ☐ **Copy that speaks to the buyer, not only the user.** Remember that the buyer may not know the product as well as the person receiving it.
- ☐ **A realistic delivery estimate shown before purchase.** Delivery timing is often the first thing a gift buyer needs to know.

Gift guide or collection URL

Published on

WHAT INFORMATION OR FEATURE STILL NEEDS TO BE ADDED?

WHAT THIS CHANGES

Before checkout, tell the customer who the product suits, what is included, when it should arrive and how returns work.

Publish your Christmas shipping deadlines

Confirm the final order date for each service, then publish deadlines early enough to affect the purchase decision.

IN PLAIN ENGLISH

A shipping cutoff is the last day you can send an order for it to arrive before Christmas. Each carrier and service level has its own.

2025 DATES SHOWN 2026 cutoffs publish in the autumn

USPS, UPS and FedEx published cutoffs

Planning placeholders only

Replace every date below with the carrier-published 2026 cutoff, then subtract your 3PL processing time and an appropriate contingency buffer before publishing a customer-facing deadline. A last ship date is not a customer order deadline.

CARRIER AND SERVICE	LAST SHIP DATE	YOUR CUSTOMER ORDER DEADLINE	BANNER PUBLISHED
USPS Ground Advantage	17 December		12 December
USPS Priority Mail	18 December		15 December
UPS 3 Day Select	19 December		16 December
FedEx Express Saver	20 December		17 December
UPS 2nd Day Air	22 December		20 December
UPS and FedEx overnight	23 December		22 December
Digital gift cards	No shipping deadline	Available through 25 December	23 December

A clear and accurate delivery deadline gives customers the information they need to order in time. Do not rely on countdown widgets or low-stock messages instead. Confirm 2026 dates with [UPS](#) and [FedEx](#), and [check USPS for the latest holiday shipping deadlines](#).

Person responsible for publishing updates

Where the banner appears

WHAT THIS CHANGES

Once Christmas delivery is no longer possible for physical products, update the homepage, gift guide, email and advertising to prioritise digital gift cards. Choose the switch date now and add it to your campaign calendar.

Plan customer-support coverage for Cyber Week

Customers will have more questions during Cyber Week, especially about delivery, discounts, returns and order changes.

IN PLAIN ENGLISH

A saved reply is a pre-written answer you can insert in one click. Proactive shipping notifications are the automatic emails telling someone their order has shipped and where it is.

THE DOMINANT TICKET TYPE **Where is my order?**

Gorgias peak season playbook, 2025

- ☐ **Who is covering which hours, written down.** Include Saturday and Sunday.
- ☐ **Saved replies for the questions you expect.** Delivery times, discount codes not applying, sizing, returns and order changes.
- ☐ **Shipping and returns policies reachable within two clicks.** From the product page, cart and footer. Most of these tickets are a navigation problem.
- ☐ **Proactive order and shipping notifications are active and tested.** Clear automatic updates reduce the number of customers who need to contact support.
- ☐ **A response time your team can realistically meet.** Publish it, and base it on the hours and people available.

Cover on Friday

Cover on Saturday

Cover on Cyber Monday

COMMON CUSTOMER QUESTIONS AND WHERE THE ANSWERS APPEAR

WHAT THIS CHANGES

If customers repeatedly ask the same question, add the answer to the relevant product, shipping, returns or order-status page.

Track your Black Friday performance daily

Complete this page at the same time each evening from Thanksgiving through Cyber Monday. Compare each day with breakeven, plan and last year. Revenue matters, but it needs to be read alongside margin, advertising cost, conversion and stock.

IN PLAIN ENGLISH

Blended ROAS means your total sales divided by your total ad spend across everything, rather than the figure any single platform reports for itself.

COMPARE BLENDED ROAS AGAINST **Your breakeven, from page 9**

METRIC	BENCHMARK	THU	FRI	SAT	SUN	MON
Net revenue	Your daily plan and last year					
Orders	Your daily plan and last year					
Average order value	Your plan. Shopify 2025 average \$114.70 for context					
Conversion rate	Your usual rate and last year					
Cart abandonment	Your baseline. 70.2% Baymard for context					
CPM	Expect 2 to 3 times your usual cost					
Blended ROAS	Your breakeven ROAS					
Email and SMS revenue	Your plan					
Total discount rate	Your planned limit					
Top-selling product stock	Enough for the remaining forecast					

Sources for the external benchmarks appear on page 48. Compare the external benchmarks with your own targets and the figures recorded earlier in the workbook.

Marketing Budget MER Tracker

Printable sheet, downloads to your device

DOWNLOAD

WHAT THIS CHANGES

If blended ROAS remains below breakeven after late conversions have been recorded, check advertising cost, conversion rate, average order value and contribution per order before changing the budget.

08

Measure what happened after Black Friday

November shows what you sold. The following ninety days show whether those new customers return and buy again without another discount. To understand whether Black Friday was worthwhile, include returns, contribution margin and repeat purchases as well as weekend revenue. The final page records the figures and decisions you will need when planning next year.

DECEMBER INTO JANUARY

01	Compare new customers by discount use	43
02	Calculate your full-price repeat-purchase rate	44
03	Your January plan	45
04	Complete your post-event review	46

Compare new customers by discount use

Separate new customers who used a discount from those who did not. Then compare both groups with customers acquired during a normal month. In Shopify, open Customers, then Segments, and build a segment on first order date.

IN PLAIN ENGLISH

A customer group here means everyone who placed their first order in the same period. Comparing groups over time shows which acquisition produced customers who came back.

TWELVE-MONTH VALUE OF DISCOUNT-ACQUIRED CUSTOMERS **Commonly 35 to 45 percent lower**

Niblin, 2026. Use as a reference range

CUSTOMER GROUP	CUSTOMERS	AVERAGE ORDER VALUE	SECOND ORDER WITHIN 90 DAYS	SECOND ORDER WITHIN SIX MONTHS
Black Friday, discount used				
Black Friday, no discount used				
A normal trading month				

Compare the repeat-purchase rate of each Black Friday group with a normal acquisition period. There is no single repeat-purchase rate that is right for every store. Use the same measurement method and observation period for every group so the results can be compared fairly. The 35 to 45 percent figure is a useful reference, but your own customer data is what should guide next year's decision.

Repeat Customer Questions

Printable sheet, downloads to your device

DOWNLOAD

WHAT THE COMPARISON TELLS YOU

WHAT THIS CHANGES

If customers who used a discount are much less likely to buy again, account for that lower repeat-purchase rate when assessing customer acquisition cost.

Calculate your full-price repeat-purchase rate

This tells you how many Black Friday customers came back and paid full price for their next order. Check it after ninety days, then check it again after six months to get a fuller picture.

IN PLAIN ENGLISH

Full-price repeat-purchase rate is the share of customers who buy again without a discount. It separates people who wanted your product from people who wanted a deal.

THE WINDOW THE TRACKER USES **Six months from first order**

Repeat Rate Tracker

CALCULATE IT FOR YOUR BLACK FRIDAY CUSTOMER GROUP

First-time customers acquired over the weekend	
— Those who have not placed a second order	
= Customers who placed a second order	
— Customers whose second order also used a discount	
= Full-price repeat customers	

WORKED EXAMPLE

400 first-time customers, 112 placed a second order, so a repeat rate of 28 percent. If 70 of those second orders needed another discount, your full-price repeat-purchase rate is 42 divided by 400, which is 10.5 percent. Run the same math on a group acquired in a normal month and put the two side by side. If fewer Black Friday customers return at full price, the original sale may not be as valuable as it first appeared.

THE MATH

Full-price repeat-purchase rate

= full-price repeat customers ÷ first-time customers × 100

Repeat Rate Tracker

Spreadsheet, opens a copy you can edit

GET YOUR COPY

WHAT THIS CHANGES

Use this number alongside contribution margin, acquisition cost and return rate when deciding how deep to discount next year.

Your January plan

January brings a familiar mix of returns, cash commitments and opportunities to bring new customers back. Plan for them in December while the Black Friday decisions are still fresh.

IN PLAIN ENGLISH

A retention sequence is a series of emails sent to people who have already bought, to bring them back. Redemption means a gift card being spent.

META CPM IN JANUARY 2026 About 38 percent below the November peak

Sovran Benchmarks via Clouted, 2026

- ☐ **January returns.** The online return rate was 19.3 percent in 2025, and extended holiday return windows push many of those into January. Source: NRF and Happy Returns, October 2025.
- ☐ **A retention sequence tailored to the Black Friday group.** Give customers useful product guidance, a replenishment reminder or a reason to consider something they did not buy the first time.
- ☐ **Unused gift-card balances.** Make gift cards easy to redeem and help customers find products that suit the amount they have available.
- ☐ **January advertising.** Advertising costs often fall after the November peak, so decide whether to hold part of the budget for January.
- ☐ **Cash position.** Customer cash may arrive in November while supplier payments, fulfilment charges, refunds and returns continue into January.

Budget held back for January

Retention emails start on

Profit vs Cash Calculator

Free tool on our site, works in your browser

OPEN TOOL

LIST YOUR JANUARY PRIORITIES IN ORDER

WHAT THIS CHANGES

Plan for the cash leaving the business through supplier payments, refunds and returns. At the same time, make use of lower advertising costs and the new customers you have just acquired.

Complete your post-event review

Record the results while they are still fresh. It will save you and the team from piecing the details together next year. Note what worked, what did not and what you would change.

IN PLAIN ENGLISH

Sell-through is the percentage of available stock sold during the period. Anything left over ties up cash you could have used elsewhere.

DO THIS BY **Mid-January, at the latest**

EcomIQ guidance, not a measured benchmark

THE NUMBERS

Net revenue	Orders	Average order value
Contribution after returns	Total ad spend	New-customer CAC
Top-selling product sell-through	Return rate	Total refund value

THE JUDGEMENT

What sold out, and when	What did not sell	What caused problems	What worked better than expected

Continue tracking contribution, acquisition cost, returns and repeat purchases each quarter. Enter the recurring figures in the Profitability Dashboard so you can compare Black Friday with other trading periods.

Which one decision would you change next time?

Profitability Dashboard

Keep tracking these figures throughout the year

GET YOUR COPY

WHAT THIS CHANGES

Save this review with the final offer, campaign calendar and performance reports, then move the recurring figures into the Profitability Dashboard so next year's plan uses several periods of data rather than one weekend.

CONTEXT FOR YOUR OWN NUMBERS

Black Friday benchmarks

Use these figures as a reference point. Your own margin, customer mix and previous Black Friday results should guide the final decision. Seasonal benchmarks are drawn from the 2025 season or later, and the source and publication date for every figure are shown on the sources page.

WHAT	BENCHMARK	SOURCE	YOURS
Average order value, Shopify BFCM 2025	\$114.70	Shopify, Dec 2025	
Shopify BFCM 2025 merchant sales	\$14.6bn, up 27 percent	Shopify, Dec 2025	
Mobile share of orders, Thanksgiving	61.6 percent	Adobe Analytics, Dec 2025	
Shop Pay share of BFCM orders	32 percent	Shopify, Dec 2025	
Sitewide conversion rate	1.4 percent reported average	Shopify merchant data, 2026. Use your own baseline as the primary comparison	
Cart abandonment	70.2 percent	Baymard Institute, 2026	
Meta CPM during Cyber Week	2 to 3 times baseline	Gupta Media 2025, Trackbee 2026	
Meta CPM, January 2026	38 percent below the peak	Sovran via Clouted, 2026	
Email flow share of email revenue	About 41 percent	Klaviyo benchmarks, 2026	
Spam complaint rate ceiling	Under 0.3 percent	Google and Yahoo requirements	
Online return rate	19.3 percent	NRF and Happy Returns, Oct 2025	
Share of weekend spend on gifts	About 67 percent	NRF and Prosper, Dec 2025	
Carrier rate increase, 2026	5.9 percent headline	UPS and FedEx published rates	
Site speed, 0.1s faster on mobile	8.4 percent more conversions	Google and Deloitte	
Twelve-month value of discount-acquired customers	35 to 45 percent lower	Niblin, 2026. Reference range, not a universal benchmark	

Seasonal figures are from the 2025 season or later. Older supporting research is identified separately rather than presented as current seasonal data. Recommendations based on EcomIQ experience are labelled as EcomIQ guidance.

WHERE THE NUMBERS CAME FROM

Sources

Seasonal performance figures are from the 2025 season or later. Supporting research from earlier years is shown with its publication date so you can decide how useful it is for your brand. Where no reliable benchmark exists, the workbook labels the recommendation as EcomIQ guidance, so you can clearly separate published data from our own practical recommendations.

SEASON PERFORMANCE

Shopify	Black Friday Cyber Monday 2025 merchant data, investor release	2 December 2025
Adobe Analytics	2025 Cyber Week online shopping data	December 2025
National Retail Federation and Prosper Insights and Analytics	Thanksgiving weekend consumer survey	December 2025

COSTS AND MARGIN

US Customs and Border Protection	Repeal of Section 321 de minimis	29 August 2025
GingerControl	Per parcel customs entry cost analysis	2026
UPS and FedEx	Published 2026 general rate increases and surcharges	December 2025 and January 2026
LateShipment and PartnerShip	Effective rate increase analysis	2026
National Retail Federation and Happy Returns	Retail Returns Landscape	October 2025
Niblin	Discount strategy and customer lifetime value analysis	2026
Avalara and Sales Tax Institute	Economic nexus thresholds by state	August 2026

SITE AND CHECKOUT

Google and Deloitte	Milliseconds Make Millions, mobile speed and conversion	2020
HTTPArchive and Web Almanac	Core Web Vitals pass rates for ecommerce	2025
Baymard Institute	Cart abandonment rate statistics	2026
Shopify	Scripts sunset and checkout extensibility documentation	Accessed August 2026

EMAIL, SMS AND PAID MEDIA

Klaviyo	Email and SMS flow and campaign benchmarks	2026
Google and Yahoo	Bulk sender requirements	In force since February 2024
Microsoft	Sender requirements, server-level rejection	5 May 2025
Federal Communications Commission	One-to-one consent rule vacated, then repealed	January and September 2025
Gupta Media	True cost of social media advertising	2025
Sovran Benchmarks via Clouted	Meta CPM benchmarks	2026
Google	Merchant Center product data specification	2026
Gorgias	Peak season support playbook	2025

Carrier cutoff dates are 2025 actuals, used as a planning baseline until the 2026 dates publish. Anything marked EcomIQ guidance is based on our practical experience and should be tested against your own results.

SIX CLAIMS TO TEST, NOT INHERIT

Six Black Friday claims to check

These six claims appear in plenty of Black Friday advice. Check them against your own numbers before building them into the plan.

DO NOT ASSUME	You need separate one-to-one SMS consent The FCC rule was vacated in January 2025 and repealed that September. The standard is prior express written consent, as it was before. Guides written in late 2024 still repeat this.
DO NOT ASSUME	Countdown timers and low stock counters lift conversion There is no strong current evidence for this. False urgency can damage trust. Use genuine delivery dates, stock limits and offer deadlines instead.
DO NOT ASSUME	A deeper discount always produces more total contribution In the worked example on page 10, a 25 percent discount cuts contribution per order from \$59.71 to \$33.00, so you would need roughly 1.81 times the unit volume to preserve the same total contribution. The cited analysis also found twelve-month value 35 to 45 percent lower for customers acquired through discounts. Compare that finding with your own repeat-purchase data. Niblin, 2026.
DO NOT ASSUME	Open rate is enough to judge email performance Apple Mail Privacy Protection inflates it. Use revenue per recipient, clicks, conversion and attributed contribution alongside delivery metrics. Do not use open rate on its own to judge whether an email worked. Klaviyo benchmarks, 2026.
DO NOT ASSUME	Cyber Monday is automatically the most important day Black Friday generated more online revenue than Cyber Monday in both 2024 and 2025, while promotional demand also moved earlier in November. Adobe Analytics, December 2025.
DO NOT ASSUME	Revenue growth can compensate for an offer that fails the margin model More orders do not automatically repair weaker contribution. Calculate the unit volume required to recover the margin lost before approving the offer.

WHAT ELSE YOU HAVE BEEN TOLD THAT YOU ARE NO LONGER SURE ABOUT

EVERYTHING IN ONE PLACE

Calculators, spreadsheets and checklists

Use the tools below to complete the calculations and checks referenced throughout the workbook. Each spreadsheet link creates a copy you can edit with your own figures.

You can enter results from six of these tools into the Profitability Dashboard: landed cost, delivery cost, total discount rate, repeat-purchase rate, customer acquisition cost and cash cycle. Enter the figures using the same method each quarter so the results remain comparable.

SHEETS THAT GO WITH THIS WORKBOOK

Landed Product Cost Calculator Part 02 · Get your copy	Price Change Calculator Part 01 · Get your copy
Profitability Dashboard Part 01 · Get your copy	Total Discount Rate Tracker Part 01 · Get your copy
Welcome Discount Worksheet Part 02 · Get your copy	Free Shipping Threshold Test Part 02 · Get your copy
Delivery Cost Sheet Part 03 · Get your copy	Cash Cycle Calculator Part 03 · Open tool
Fulfilment Questions Part 03 · Download	Mobile Checkout Checklist Part 04 · Download
Marketing Budget MER Tracker Part 07 · Download	Repeat Customer Questions Part 08 · Download
Repeat Rate Tracker Part 08 · Get your copy	

FREE TOOLS ON OUR SITE

Email Marketing Audit Part 05 · Open tool	True CAC Calculator Part 06 · Open tool
Paid Media Audit Part 06 · Open tool	Profit vs Cash Calculator Part 08 · Open tool
DTC Founder Pulse Check Any time · Open tool	Shopify Plan Cost Calculator Any time · Open tool

Want a second pair of eyes on the numbers before you approve the offer?

Bring your contribution margin, breakeven ROAS and proposed discount

[BOOK A CALL](#)

You've built your Black Friday plan

You now have the key numbers, decisions and named responsibilities your team needs to prepare for Black Friday.

- 01 You know how much contribution each order leaves
- 02 You know the maximum discount your margin can support
- 03 Your inventory, fulfilment, checkout and marketing tasks have clear owners
- 04 You know which results to review after Black Friday

Want a second pair of eyes before you approve the plan?

Bring us your contribution margin, breakeven ROAS and proposed offer. We will check the assumptions with you, point out anything that could make the offer unprofitable and help you decide what to do next.

Practical ecommerce coaching based on your brand, your numbers and the decisions in front of you.

[BOOK A CALL](#)